Conceptual Idealism Is Not Metaphysical: Hofweber on Facts and Effability

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Abstract

Can linguistic analysis yield genuine and surprising metaphysical conclusions? Thomas Hofweber claims that Conceptual Idealism (CI)—the thesis that reality, understood as the totality of facts, is range-dependent on human minds—follows from Internalism about fact-talk as a substantial metaphysical result. This paper argues that CI, as Hofweber defends it, is metaphysically inert, exposing a recurrent problem with reasoning from language to metaphysics.

This paper's argument proceeds in two stages. First, given Hofweber's own account of quantification, the Structural Effability Thesis (SET)—that every fact is structurally effable—must be understood on its inferential reading: a conjunction of internal, language-relative claims of the form 'that-p is structurally effable'. Since each conjunct of SET is purely linguistic and metaphysically inert, so too is their conjunction. Thus, SET cannot bear the metaphysical load assigned to it.

Second, by tracking Hofweber's commitments across languages of varying expressive power through a revised impoverished-language objection, it is revealed that 'facts' within his system just means 'effable facts expressible in my language'. CI thus collapses to the claim that what we can truly state is limited by what we can state, which is a linguistic truism, not a metaphysical discovery.

Hofweber's framework is therefore committed to a de facto quietism. It cannot coherently pose the question of structural effability as a genuine metaphysical question, let alone resolve it in favour of idealism. Internalism does not entail metaphysical idealism, and this mode of failure haunts the linguistic approaches to metaphysics which have seen a renaissance in recent years.

1 Introduction

In this paper, I argue that 'Conceptual Idealism' (CI, hereinafter), as defended by Thomas Hofweber, fails to qualify as a substantial metaphysical conclusion. That is, CI is metaphysically inert, and any metaphysical reading of CI is unjustified by Hofweber's arguments. This exposes a recurring problem with the contemporary neo-Carnapian renaissance of mind-dependent metaphysics, notable proponents of which include Thomasson and Hirsch among others.

I begin by outlining CI and Hofweber's relevant commitments and arguments for this position (§2). I then argue that CI does not have the metaphysical weight that Hofweber intends it to (§3). I clarify this by examining Hofweber's treatment of 'facts' in his response to the 'impoverished-language objection' (§4). To avoid the problems that arise for traditional realist replies to CI, I demonstrate that my objections to CI entail no commitments to any particular account of quantification over facts. I argue that this commits Hofweber to a de facto quietism about structural effability (§5). This paper culminates in establishing the metaphysical insignificance of the 'Structural Effability Thesis' (SET, hereinafter) and subsequently of CI. In my concluding remarks, I consider how this failure to bridge the language-metaphysics gap is instructive beyond Hofweber's system (§6).

2 Hofweber's Conceptual Idealism

Hofweber argues that (the metaphysical conclusion) CI follows from (the linguistic theory) Internalism (about talk about facts).

CI "[T]he version of [strong] alethic idealism which holds that reality as the totality of facts is range-dependent on us [=human minds]" (Hofweber 2023, p. 76).

To better understand Hofweber's conclusions, this section offers an overview of the five key commitments that Hofweber utilises to establish CI. The first is *Strong Alethic Idealism*: human minds are central to reality, when 'reality' is understood as the totality of facts (Hofweber 2023, pp. 5–6, 16).[1] The second is *Internalism (about talk about facts)*: when we (humans) talk about facts, fact-terms ('that-p', 'the-fact-that-p', &c.) do not generally aim to refer to entities, and quantifiers over fact-terms are 'used in their inferential reading' (Hofweber 2023, pp. 72, 80). The third is *Structural Ineffability*: "F is structurally ineffable [for humans] if none of ... [our]

[1] I cite Hofweber's most recent articulation of each claim, except in cases where multiple articulations are particularly informative.

forms of representation ... are suitable to represent a fact with the structure F" (Hofweber 2023, p. 65). The fourth is *Range-dependence*: "the totality of facts range-depends on us [=humans] ... [iff] ... which facts can in principle obtain, is tied to us" (Hofweber 2023, p. 76).

Hofweber's fifth key commitment—the polysemy of quantifiers—requires a more in-depth overview. Hofweber supposes that quantifier expressions have the two following readings: the Domain Conditions Reading (DCR), wherein quantifiers range over the domain of all objects;[2] the Inferential Reading (IR), wherein quantifiers can be expanded into the conjunction or disjunction of all relevant expressions (Hofweber 2023, pp. 69–70; 2016b, p. 68). Notationally, we can specify the meanings of some expression (F) as either DCR(F) or IR(F). Thus, an expression in English might represent two entirely separate *meanings*. Consider the following example:

Num 'Something is a number'

DCR(Num) $\exists x[N(x)]$

where x represents any object, and N reads 'is a number'.

IR(Num) $N(t_1) \vee N(t_2) \vee N(t_3) \vee \dots$ &c.

i.e., $\bigvee N(t)$

where t represents any 'singular expression' in our language.[3]

Regarding Num, Hofweber concludes—agreeing, to this extent, with Carnap—that on the DCR Num is false, and on the IR Num is trivially true (Hofweber 2016a, pp. 15, 24–25). That is, IR(Num) is true, but it is not a substantial metaphysical result. Hofweber later avoids labelling IR readings as 'trivial', preferring to focus on the equal (factually contentful) status of both readings (Hofweber 2023, p. 70; 2016a, p. 25). However, when Hofweber highlights that "[DCR and IR] are simply two different readings of the same expression ... different, but *equal* readings", it is important to remember that the *expression* is not our primary concern (Hofweber 2023, p. 70). These two readings are 'equal' in that they are both coherent propositions that could reasonably be ascribed to the relevant expression. However, what is more important for the present discussion is the *meanings* of the expression; and there is an important sense in which the respective *meanings* of these two readings are clearly not 'equal'. One reading, IR, is a linguistic proposition and the other, DCR, is a metaphysical proposition. This is exemplified by IR(Num) making the linguistic claim that the listed expressions are true, whereas DCR(Num) metaphysically posits the existence of at least one entity of a particular type.

[2] This resembles the Quinean (1948), external account of quantification.

[3] '$\bigvee$' here can be read 'the disjunction of all instances of ...', in line with Hofweber's notation (2023, p. 72).

As Hofweber's main contention is a conditional one—that CI follows from Internalism—and this conditional is what I contest in this paper, I will not focus on the plausibility of the commitments discussed in this section. I will grant them for the purposes of this paper. This allows for the objections in the remainder of this paper to show that the conditional claim fails and CI is not vindicated *even if* Hofweber's linguistic foundations are sound.

In order to establish CI, Hofweber poses the structural effability question:

(SE?) "Are there any structurally ineffable facts?" (Hofweber 2023, p. 111).

He considers the following potential answers (Hofweber 2023, p. 74):

Structural Effability Thesis (SET) "Every fact is structurally effable"

Structural Ineffability Thesis (∼SET) "There are structurally ineffable facts"

Hofweber argues that Internalism guarantees the truth of SET—which he also frames as the 'structural harmony' of minds and world—and claims that this is a 'substantial result' (Hofweber 2023, pp. 75, 122). Additionally, Hofweber argues that facts do not exist—there are no entities called 'facts'—and that quantifiers over fact-terms are used in their IR (Hofweber 2023, pp. 108–109, 212). This aligns with his Internalism; for example, that 'all facts are true' is intended to mean $\bigvee T(f)$, rather than $\forall x[F(x) \implies T(x)]$. This leads Hofweber to ultimately conclude that CI is a true and metaphysically substantial conclusion; one which follows from Internalism by way of a 'straightforward argument' (Hofweber 2023, pp. 76, 207; 2019, p. 716).

3 The Metaphysically Inert Structural Effability Thesis

In this section, I argue that SET—one of Hofweber's most important conclusions for establishing CI—is metaphysically inert, and thus does not support any metaphysically substantial understanding of CI. Let us first consider, alongside Hofweber, some helpful examples (Hofweber 2016a, p. 24; 2023, p. 70):

Num 'Something is a number'

E 'Everything exists'

The meaning of these expressions are determined by the reading of their quantifiers. DCR(Num) is an external, metaphysical claim and IR(Num) is an internal, metaphysically inert (mathematical) claim. Importantly, even in cases where IR seems more substantial than DCR, it remains a claim about *language* rather than metaphysics. For instance, DCR(E) is a trivially true *meta-*

physical claim (that every existent thing is indeed existent) and IR(E) is a substantially false *language* claim (that all propositions of the form 't exists' are true) (Hofweber 2023, pp. 70–71). This remains true for Hofweber's response to (SE?):

(SET) "Every fact is structurally effable"

If we read SET as meaning IR(SET) (i.e., $\bigwedge(F(t) \implies E(t))$)[4]—and indeed, even if we disallow the DCR over fact-terms altogether—then SET is metaphysically inert.[5] That is:

1. According to Hofweber's own interpretation, 'that-p is effable' is a metaphysically inert, internal claim about language (for any p).
2. A conjunction of two metaphysically inert claims is itself metaphysically inert.
3. IR(SET) is constructed by the repeated conjunction of 'that-p is effable' expressions.

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∴ IR(SET) is itself metaphysically inert.

This alone is problematic for the metaphysicality of Hofweber's conclusion, as IR(SET) is the proper reading of SET according to Internalism, and IR(SET) is metaphysically inert.

Further, even if Hofweber allows for the alternative reading of SET, he still cannot support CI. DCR(SET) (i.e., $\forall x[F(x) \implies E(x)]$) is true according to Hofweber, but only insofar as no facts whatsoever exist.[6] This follows directly from Internalism: since fact-terms do not refer to entities, the domain of any DCR quantification over facts is empty. A universally quantified claim over an empty domain is *vacuously* true, and carries no metaphysical weight. Thus, DCR(SET) is no justification for CI, as no facts existing entails that neither effable nor ineffable facts exist, and so it cannot ground any form of idealism.

Reframing IR(SET) as 'the structural harmony of minds and facts' *sounds* more substantial, but it is not so (Hofweber 2023, p. 65). Hofweber's reframing IR(SET) in this way does not further his cause. Still, then, no metaphysical conclusion has yet been established. This becomes apparent by removing the ambiguous (metaphysical-seeming) English expression altogether. If we refrain from expressing IR(SET) as SET, then it is clear that IR(SET) is metaphysically inert.

[4] $F(t)$ = 't is a fact', $E(t)$ = 't is structurally effable', and t is any singular expression (Hofweber 2023, p. 74).

[5] Hofweber affirms that DCR and IR are always 'in principle available', although Internalism suggests the use of IR (Hofweber 2023, pp. 84, 108). I consider both readings in order to demonstrate that *neither* can serve CI.

[6] Here, Hofweber and I both assume a contemporary (Quinean) account of existential import. However, it is worth noting that even on an Aristotelian reading of DCR(SET), wherein it *does* have existential import, it still fails CI on account of its being contrary to Internalism (Aristotle 1997, 1011$^{\text{b}}$25; Frege 1879, §12; Quine 1948).

As such, a more accurate (though infinitely tedious) English expression of IR(SET) would be '(that-p) is effable, and (that-q) is effable, ... &c.', which is not (nor does it strike us as) metaphysically substantial. We should not be fooled by appearances; labelling IR(SET) as SET does not make the meaning any more metaphysically substantial. Therefore, if quantifiers (over fact-terms) must be read in their IR, then the metaphysical inertness of IR(SET) is apparent; even if Hofweber allows for both readings of SET, the metaphysical reading (DCR(SET)) is vacuous and cannot support CI. In either case, there is no metaphysically substantial basis for CI to be found in SET. The metaphysical triviality of IR(SET) is maintained even if we *necessarily* must read SET as meaning IR(SET). Thus, Hofweber's SET can only justify a version of CI that is itself metaphysically inert.[7]

4 'Facts' and Impoverished Languages

In order to further demonstrate and explain the metaphysical inertness of CI, this section outlines an altered version of Nagel's 'impoverished-language objection' (or the 'alien objection') (Nagel 1986, pp. 92–99; Hofweber 2023, p. 85; 2019, pp. 728–729). This objection has substantial force independently, but I retool the argument here in order to—in conjunction with my previous objection—clarify CI and illuminate *how* Hofweber defends a metaphysically inert statement as though it is a substantial metaphysical conclusion. That is, I alter this objection to highlight exactly why Hofweber's response to the traditional objection fails, and how Hofweber's conception of 'facts' ties into CI's metaphysical inertness.

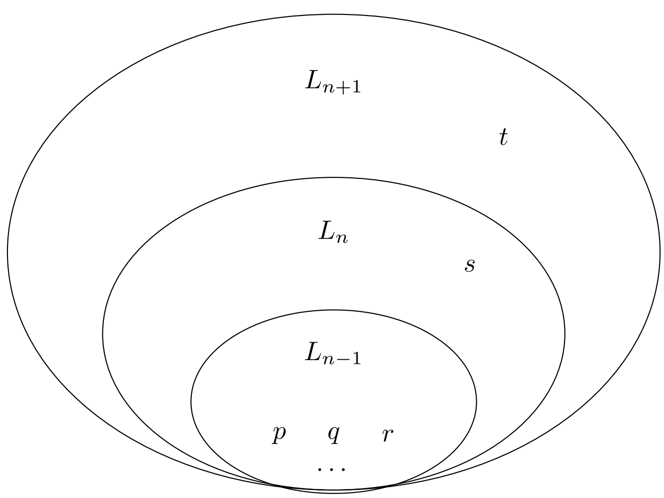

Figure 1: Languages with Different Expressive Powers.

[7] An explicit articulation of a metaphysically inert, trivial CI can be found below (pp. 8–9).

Suppose our language (L_n) can represent n many facts. Consider the potential for a language that can express one less fact (L_{n-1}), and a language that can express one more fact (L_{n+1}). This can be visualised as in *Figure 1.* Hofweber acknowledges that an L_{n-1} (impoverished-English) speaker can truthfully say 'There are no facts ineffable for L_{n-1} speakers' (that is, as spoken in L_{n-1}, SET_{n-1}), but by 'facts' they mean something different from what L_n speakers mean by 'facts'. He further acknowledges that it is therefore also true for us (L_n speakers) to say that there *is* some 'fact' (namely, s) that is ineffable for an L_{n-1} speaker (Hofweber 2023, p. 85). Similarly, an L_{n+1} speaker can theoretically point to a counterexample to SET_n (namely, t).[8] If t is a fact, then SET_n is false, and thus Hofweber is forced to reject that t is a fact. Hofweber highlights that ∼SET as spoken in L_{n+1} ($\sim SET_{n+1}$) would not mean ∼SET as we understand it ($\sim SET_n$) (Hofweber 2023, pp. 85–86).

As there is no other relevant difference between any of the described languages, SET_{n-1} must differ from SET_n (and SET_{n+1}) as its meaning of 'all facts' is simply '... p & q & r', whereas for an L_n speaker, 'all facts' means '... p & q & r & s'. Thus, it seems that according to Hofweber's use of the term, 'facts' in a given language are 'that which corresponds to my language's fact-terms' or 'effable facts'. In that case, let us call what they (= L_{n-1} speakers) are talking about when they say 'facts' $facts_{n-1}$. Similarly, when we (= L_n speakers) say 'facts' we really mean $facts_n$, and t is not a $fact_n$. However, a consequence of this line of thought is that just as s is a $fact_n$ but not a $fact_{n-1}$, t is indeed a $fact_{n+1}$ (but not a $fact_n$). This clarification of Hofweber's conception of 'facts' once again highlights the metaphysical inertness of the conclusion he is committed to. That is, Hofweber's CI can be clarified thus:

a) Reality is range-dependent on our minds. (CI)

b) The totality of facts is range-dependent on our minds. (substituting 'reality')

c) The totality of meanings of fact-terms is range-dependent on our minds. (substituting 'facts')

i.e., The set of things we can truly state is limited by the set of things we can state.

The substantial metaphysical conclusion Hofweber takes himself to be arguing for is something like 'All facts are effable', where 'facts' is absolute (roughly, $fact_{n+\infty}$). However, for Hofweber, the expression 'facts' really means $facts_n$ and thus incorporates effability (in L_n) into his understanding of the term 'fact'. This renders Hofweber's CI as a mere linguistic tautology which

[8] 'SET', as it has been used thus far, means SET_n.

ceases to make any claim about reality whatsoever, thereby stripping the term 'idealism' of any metaphysical significance. This is highlighted even further by Hofweber's commitment to the idea that anything that might be said to be true (in L_{n+1}) but not representable in our language (namely, t) would not be a 'fact' (i.e., a $fact_n$) at all. Thus, his supposedly substantial conclusion, 'SET', becomes 'All $facts_n$ are effable (in L_n)' which, though true, is metaphysically inconsequential.

5 Quantification and Quietism

Typically, a critique of Hofweber's CI—now clarified as meaning $IR(CI_n)$—would be thought to require some alternative account of quantification. Indeed, Nagel's defence of realism incurs such a burden, for it is unclear how—at least, on Hofweber's account of quantification—one could coherently articulate the truth or possibility of ∼SET (Hofweber 2023, pp. 64–66; Nagel 1986, pp. 90–91, 93). However, this cannot defend Hofweber's position from the objections outlined in this essay, because this paper does not defend any metaphysical position whatsoever. My claim is rather that Hofweber's purportedly metaphysical conclusion, $IR(CI_n)$, is in fact metaphysically inert, rather than supposing CI is outright false. As such, I am not committed to ∼SET or any particular metaphysical position. I do not claim that $IR(CI_n)$ is an incorrect metaphysical position, but rather that it is not a metaphysical claim at all; the appearance of the metaphysicality of $IR(CI_n)$ is a mere artefact of its expression (for example, in English).

While I do adapt a variation of a Nagelian argument (§4), I do not use this argument to reach realism as Nagel does (Nagel 1986, p. 95); this argument only serves to highlight Hofweber's restrictive use of the term 'fact'. Furthermore, as I deny that $IR(CI_n)$ is a metaphysical conclusion at all, there is no need to commit to any peculiar account of quantification. We can simply and plainly state that $IR(CI_n)$ may well be true, but it is not relevant to metaphysics, and it is thus misleading to label it a form of 'idealism', or express it with 'CI'.[9]

My main contention is that $IR(CI_n)$—alongside $IR(\sim SET_n)$ and $IR(SET_n)$—is metaphysically inert. This conclusion depends on no particular reading of quantifiers, as it is a conclusion about a particular proposition ($IR(CI_n)$), not about an English expression (CI). In this case, (SE?) ceases to be a genuine metaphysical question at all, at least, not within Hofweber's framework. Whether there is a genuine metaphysical question that (SE?) is gesturing at remains to

[9] For further discussion on the relationship between expressibility and truth potential, see: Hofweber 2024; Kaplan 1989; Boyle 1972; Bonney 1966; Mackie 1964.

be seen; but what has been demonstrated is that Hofweber's framework only allows for it to be read either as non-metaphysical (i.e., $IR(SE?_n)$) or trivial (i.e., $DCR(SE?_n)$) and thereby irrelevant to any potential metaphysical CI.

This places CI in an unfortunate position. The stated ambition of CI is to deploy linguistic analysis as a route to the genuinely metaphysical conclusion that reality is mind-dependent. However, the framework surrounding CI precludes this ambition. Within Hofweber's framework, no answer to (SE?) can support CI. The unintentional result is a de facto quietism about any genuine metaphysical question that (SE?) might represent (Hofweber 2023, pp. 67, 78; 2019, p. 709).

6 Conclusion

The objections presented in this paper serve to clarify Hofweber's articulation of CI and related conclusions, which now read as the following, evidently metaphysically inert claims:

SET	"All facts are structurally effable"
means $IR(SET_n)$	$\forall\varphi,\ s.t.\ \varphi \in S,\ \varphi$ is effable for L_n speakers,
	wherein S is the set of all true statements in L_n.
CI	"The totality of all facts range-depends on our minds"
means $IR(CI_n)$	S range-depends on L_n.

Even if one were to reformulate CI as metaphysically substantial, this would be unsupported by Hofweber's arguments. Therefore, as defended by Hofweber, CI is metaphysically inert and thus fails to do the theoretical work intended for it. The purportedly metaphysical position, CI, is revealed to be an internal, linguistic claim. Internalism (about talk about facts) does not commit one to metaphysical idealism. More precisely: the label 'idealism' is not just misplaced here, it is actively distorting and imports connotations of genuine mind-dependence that $IR(CI_n)$ simply cannot bear. Someone who is persuaded by Hofweber's Internalism has no apparent reason whatsoever to suppose that reality, in any metaphysically substantial sense, depends on human minds.

The implications of this result expand beyond Hofweber's CI. His more recent 'immanent metaphysics' similarly relies on the bridging of the language-metaphysics gap that CI was intended to establish (Hofweber 2024, pp. 162–163, 177–178). However, as this paper has demonstrated, that gap has not been bridged. More broadly, this failure exemplifies a recurring problem for linguistic approaches to metaphysics: truths about the structure of language are often mistaken for truths about the structure of reality. This is an especially acute worry today, given the neo-Carnapian idealist renaissance in recent years, wherein linguistic and conceptual analysis routinely support mind-dependent accounts of reality.[10] What Hofweber's case makes clear is that the language-metaphysics gap remains open. Those who intend to argue from one side of it to the other must first find a bridge across; Hofweber's route, it turns out, never bridged the gap at all.

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[10] Prominent examples include: Price et al.'s expressivism (2013), Thomasson's easy ontology (2014), Hirsch and Warren's quantifier variance (2019), Hirsch's stipulative ontology (2021), and Hofweber's conceptual idealism (2016, 2023).

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